When Shah Shuja first came to power in 1803, he had gone out of his way to try and end the blood feud with the Barakzais and bring them back into the fold. The Barakzai brothers were forgiven and welcomed to court, while to seal the new alliance Shuja married their sister, Wa'fa Begum. At first all seemed well; but the Barakzais were merely waiting for their opportunity to avenge their father, and as soon as Shah Mahmoud escaped from the Bala Hisar, Fatteh Khan and Dost Mohammad immediately rallied to his standard and joined the rebellion.

Shortly after Elphinstone's Embassy arrived in Peshawar, Shah Mahmoud and the Barakzai rebels seized the southern Afghan capital of Kandahar. A month later, on 17 April 1809, just as Elphinstone and Shuja were finalising the wording of their treaty, the rebels captured Kabul itself. They then made preparations to attack Shah Shuja in Peshawar. The situation was made more critical by the fact that the bulk of Shuja's army was away fighting another rebellion in Kashmir, and around the same time as the news came of the loss of Kabul, reports began to arrive that all was not well with the Kashmir campaign either: the two nobles put in charge of the attack had quarrelled, and one had gone over to the rebels.

With the King distracted, Elphinstone and his party were left to their own devices and began their intelligence gathering, questioning traders and scholars from different parts of Afghanistan, and asking about the geography and trade and tribal customs. Emissaries were sent out: one Mullah Najib, for example, was paid fifty rupees and despatched to gather information about the Siyah Posh of Kafirstan, said to be the descendants of Alexander the Great's Greek legions. Elphinstone found Shah Shuja's munshi, or secretary, an especially rich source of information: 'a man of retired and studious habits, but really a man of genius, and of insatiable thirst for knowledge. Though well versed in metaphysics, and the moral sciences known in his country, his passion was for mathematics, and he was studying Sanskrit with a view to discovering the treasures of Hindoo learning.' There were other thinkers and intellectuals in the court too, who between them were 'in possession of the greatest part of the learning of the country . . . Moollas, some learned, some worldly, some Deists, some rigid Mahommedans and some overflowing with the mystical doctrines of the Soofees'.[43]

The Shah allowed Elphinstone and his party to use the royal pleasure gardens, and having risen early to pursue their researches, they would break